

INTO THE HIGH COUNTRY

9 Days · Paro · Punakha · Laya

A journey that moves from the cultivated valleys of western Bhutan into the highlands of Laya — one of the kingdom's most remote settlements, sitting above the treeline at 3,800 metres. The days unfold through monasteries, mountain passes, and glacial rivers before settling into the rhythm of the highlands, where the Layap people still live in close relationship with the land and the yak herds that sustain them. The pace remains unhurried throughout. This is what it feels like to move deeper into Bhutan.

Day 1 | Arrival — Prayer Flags and a Farmhouse Kitchen

Arrive into the Paro Valley. Afternoon: print prayer flags using hand-carved wooden blocks. Visit a local farmhouse to cook a Bhutanese meal over a traditional mud stove — slow fire, seasonal ingredients, unhurried.

Day 2 | The Tiger's Nest

Full day hike to the Tiger's Nest through blue pine forest — 2 to 3 hours up. Time inside the monastery before descending. Evening: a traditional hot stone bath infused with medicinal herbs.

Day 3 | Over the Pass — Into the Warm Valley

Drive from Paro to Punakha via a high mountain pass marked by 108 memorial chortens. Descend into the warmer lowland valley. Visit the great dzong at the confluence of two rivers — one of Bhutan's most significant landmarks. Evening at a farmhouse: momo-making session and a farm dinner.

Day 4 | The Road to Laya

Drive north for approximately 5 hours, following a glacial river upstream as the valley narrows into dense forest. When the road ends, continue on foot for 2 hours — a steady ascent through forest, crossing wooden bridges, the air cooling with every hour. Arrive in Laya.

Day 5 | With the Yak Herders

Spend the day with the yak herders of Laya — walking out to the grazing grounds, observing the daily work of the high-altitude herding life, and gathering around the hearth of a stone shelter built for warmth and endurance at 3,800 metres. The rest of the day belongs to the mountains.

Day 6 | Laya — A Day in the Settlement

A full, unhurried day in one of Bhutan's most remote highland communities. Move slowly through the settlement, visit homes, and spend time with the families who still live in close relationship with the land, the seasons, and the animals that sustain them.

Day 7 | Return to the Valley

Trek out of Laya and drive back to Punakha. Rest and a slow dinner in the warm valley.

Day 8 | Return to Paro — Optional Experiences

Drive from Punakha back to Paro. The afternoon is at leisure. Optional: a private sand mandala session, a butter lamp offering, or an obstacle-clearing ceremony held inside a private heritage home. Optional evening: a Bhutanese astrology reading by the fire.

Day 9 | Departure

After breakfast, transfer to the airport for your onward journey.